that even by 1951, important Indian leaders were already alarmed by the impracticality of our diplomatic outlook.

Among Ambedkar's specific grievances in this regard, one pertained to the handling of the US, which he articulated in 1951 in the 'Election Manifesto of the Scheduled Castes Federation' that had a section devoted to problems of foreign policy. Like Patel, who had passed away a year before, Ambedkar too was concerned about Nehru's outlook towards China. But, perhaps due to intervening events, he was now connecting it to India–US ties. In essence, Ambedkar asked why India was fighting China's battle for permanent membership of the UNSC. In his view, this championing by India had created antagonism with the US and jeopardized the prospect of getting financial and technical resources from that country.

In what we would unquestionably recognize today as a declaration of 'India First', Dr Ambedkar sharply emphasizes that India's first duty should be to herself. In his view, instead of trying to make China a member of the UNSC, India should get itself recognized instead. His characterization of the Nehruvian approach was of it being quixotic, if not suicidal. And his remedy was that India should focus on building its own strength instead of championing the interests of other Asian states. On another occasion, he expressed the same sentiments in his assertion that the keynote of our foreign policy appeared to be to solve the problems of others rather than of ourselves.

Like many of his generation, Ambedkar was obviously deeply conversant with international affairs and visibly invested in its formulation. His plea was clearly not one of turning India's back on the world but instead of making choices that would be primarily driven by our country's gains. In that sense, his endeavour was to get the balance between our national interest and international posture. And like many contemporaries, he appeared to believe that Nehru was leaning far too much in the direction of the latter at the expense of the former.

Ambedkar, too, shared the sense that India was being naïve in its unquestioning acceptance of the principles of Panchsheel. His own view was that they had no place in politics; nor did he believe that China, in its heart of hearts, differed on this matter. In a revealing parliamentary discussion in August 1954 where he laid out his viewpoint, Ambedkar also made a strong case for an interest-based diplomacy. He questioned what he termed Nehru's advocacy of 'Asia for Asiatics', suggesting that greater